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Lesson 3. Call to Repentance, Belief, and Baptism

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Lesson 3. Call to Repentance, Belief, and Baptism

I. UNDERSTANDING REPENTANCE

- A. Repentance involves turning from sin and turning toward God, a complete change in direction—heart, mind, and action.
- B. **Definition and Necessity:** Repentance is foundational to receiving forgiveness and experiencing new life in Christ. Jesus proclaimed, “Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand” (Matthew 4:17, ESV). It’s not merely feeling regret but actively forsaking sin and pursuing righteousness.
- C. **Practical Expression:** True repentance involves acknowledging sin, experiencing genuine sorrow over offending God, confessing specific sins to Him, and actively turning away from wrongdoing (2 Corinthians 7:10-11). Zacchaeus demonstrates true repentance by immediately righting his wrongs (Luke 19:8-9).
- D. **Ongoing Practice:** Repentance isn’t a one-time event but a continual posture of humility and surrender before God (1 John 1:9).

II. BELIEF: TRUSTING IN CHRIST

- A. Belief, or faith, is more than intellectual agreement—it’s an active and personal trust in Jesus Christ as Savior and Lord.
- B. **Nature of Saving Faith:** Saving faith believes wholeheartedly in the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ as the exclusive means of salvation. Paul emphasizes, “because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved” (Romans 10:9, ESV).
- C. **Faith as Relationship:** Belief involves a continuous trust and daily dependence on Jesus. It transforms every area of life as believers grow in obedience and reliance on Him, empowered by the Holy Spirit (Galatians 2:20, John 15:4-5).
- D. **Faith Tested and Proven:** True belief endures trials, affirming genuine trust in God’s promises and character (1 Peter 1:6-7).

III. BAPTISM: PUBLIC DECLARATION OF FAITH

- A. Baptism is a visible, public affirmation of repentance and belief, symbolizing a believer’s union with Christ in His death, burial, and resurrection.
- B. **Biblical Command:** Baptism is commanded explicitly by Jesus in the Great Commission, making it integral to disciple-making: “Go therefore and make

disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit” (Matthew 28:19, ESV).

- C. **Symbolic Significance:** Baptism symbolizes dying to an old life of sin and rising to new life in Christ. “We were buried therefore with him by baptism into death, in order that, just as Christ was raised from the dead... we too might walk in newness of life” (Romans 6:4, ESV).
- D. **Community Witness and Accountability:** Baptism serves as a testimony to the believing community and creates accountability for the baptized believer, reinforcing commitment and mutual encouragement (Hebrews 10:24-25).

IV. PRACTICAL STEPS FOR CALLING PEOPLE TO REPENTANCE, BELIEF, AND BAPTISM

- A. **Clear Gospel Presentation:** Clearly articulate the Gospel message, emphasizing the holiness of God, human sinfulness, the need for repentance, Christ’s redemptive work, and the necessity of personal trust in Him.
- B. **Invitation and Response:** Offer clear, direct opportunities for individuals to respond publicly and immediately through repentance, confession of belief, and baptism.
- C. **Discipleship Follow-Up:** Ensure immediate and ongoing discipleship to nurture new believers, helping them grow in understanding, obedience, and maturity in Christ.

V. CASE EXAMPLE

In a rural village in China, many men and women had been touched by the good news of salvation. Through grace and forgiveness, they left their old pagan beliefs and works-based religion to receive Jesus and enthrone Him as Lord of their lives. Although their salvation was secure, these precious believers desired to follow the Lord in water baptism. Fearing for their safety, they waited for an opportunity to present itself. Soon after, an evangelistic church planting team from a nearby city made a memorable trip to visit these men, women, and children. The team rented a hotel room with a large bathtub and then baptized each new believer one by one by immersing them in the tub. Each one came out of the water with a smile that was bright and evident of the Lord’s joy and new life. Today, these believers have grown and matured and are now reaching hundreds of other villages with the same Gospel message. They, too, are following the creative opportunities to baptize new believers as often as possible.

VI. CONCLUSION

Calling people to repentance, belief, and baptism is central to effective discipling. This comprehensive and clear approach aligns closely with biblical commands and patterns, fostering genuine transformation, strong public confessions, and robust discipling movements (Acts 2:41-47).

This lesson was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org).

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In Christ,

The JesusOnline Ministries Team

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